A History of Famines

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Podcast Transcript

One of the most devastating disasters that has afflicted humanity are famines.

Unlike other natural disasters, famines do not have a single cause. They have happened all over the world for a wide variety of reasons; some of them have natural causes, and others are man-made.

Famines are typically much worse than natural disasters and are rivaled only by pandemics and wars.

Learn more about famines, their causes, and how they devastated humanity throughout history on this episode of Everything Everywhere Daily.

The genesis of this episode came from my efforts to come up with a list of the worst things that have ever happened to humans in history.

I found lists of the greatest disasters ever to impact humanity. On the list were a lot of pandemics, natural disasters, and famines.

I've covered some of these in the past, and I'll be covering more of these in the future as they have had an enormous impact on history.

However, famines are very different than an earthquake or an outbreak of a disease. I don't want to say that every natural disaster or pandemic is the same as they are not, but they are very different than famines.

A famine can be the result of several different possible events. You can prepare for a natural disaster, but you usually can't prevent it from happening. Famines often are totally preventable, however.

Also, unlike natural disasters, famines have become more and more rare as we have mastered the production and distribution of food.

So, let's start by defining what a famine is. Famine is a severe and widespread shortage of food, leading to acute hunger, starvation, malnutrition, and often death.

The concept is pretty simple, but the circumstances surrounding them are not.

Famines, as they are understood today, did not exist in the same way before the advent of agriculture. In hunter-gatherer societies, food shortages occurred due to environmental changes, resource depletion, or population pressures, but the nature of these shortages and how they were managed differed significantly:

That isn't to say starvation didn't occur, but it seldom resulted in widescale hunger.

Hunter-gatherers relied on various foods, including plants, animals, fish, and insects. This dietary diversity provided resilience against localized resource failures. If one food source declined, they could often rely on others.

Hunter-gatherers were highly mobile. When resources in one area became scarce, they could move to another region where food was more abundant.

Pre-agricultural societies tended to have lower population densities, which reduced competition for resources and made it easier for smaller groups to sustain themselves.

Deep knowledge of the natural world allowed hunter-gatherers to exploit seasonal and regional resources efficiently, reducing the likelihood of prolonged shortages.

Despite these adaptive strategies, food shortages did occur, especially during extreme environmental change. Hunter-gatherers employed several strategies to cope.

They expanded their diets to include less preferred or harder-to-process foods, such as roots, tubers, wild grasses, or smaller game. Some groups turned to foods with high preparation costs, like acorns, which required extensive processing to remove toxins.

During lean periods, hunter-gatherers practiced resource conservation by limiting hunting and foraging to avoid depleting available stocks entirely. They also used limited food storage if they had the means, such as drying or fermenting foods.

The average hunter-gatherer probably was always a few weeks or even days from hunger, but their nimble lifestyle allowed them to adapt accordingly.

Strangely enough, the rise of agriculture was probably a response to food insecurity and was also the cause of famines.

There is a great deal of debate as to why humans switched from hunting to farming. However, one of the most popular theories is that agriculture offered humans a more steady supply of food.

Instead of having to move with the season and herds constantly, the domestication of crops and animals allowed people to stay put. They could store grain, harvest their animals as needed, and eliminate the daily quest for food that dominated the lives of hunter-gatherers.

However, there was a catch.

Farming was great in terms of food security until the point that something disrupted the system. If that happened, then agriculturalists were now in a worse position than the hunter-gatherers.

They couldn't drop everything to go hunt. Moreover, they didn't have the skills or tools to do that, and the high population supported by agriculture meant that wild game and plants would be exhausted quickly.

The result was a famine.

One of the earliest known famines was a widespread event that affected much of the Earth, known as the 4.2-kiloyear event.

The 4.2-kiloyear event, occurring around 2200 BCE, was a major climatic disruption marked by widespread aridity and cooling that lasted for approximately 200 years. This event significantly impacted civilizations across the globe, particularly in the Near East, North Africa, and the Indus Valley, where it caused severe droughts, reduced agricultural productivity, and social upheaval. The Akkadian Empire collapsed, and the Egyptian Old Kingdom went into decline, as did the Indus Valley Civilization.

The Famine Stela is an ancient Egyptian inscription located on Sehel Island near Aswan, dating to the Ptolemaic period but recounting events from the Old Kingdom. It tells of a seven-year famine during the reign of Pharaoh Djoser, caused by the Nile's failure to flood adequately.

Famines begin appearing periodically in this historical record all over the world.

Around the year 100 BC, there was a great famine reported during the Han Dynasty in China. This, like many of the early famines, was caused by drought.

Around the same time, a widespread famine occurred in Sri Lanka.

In 26 BC, historian Flavius Josephus reported a famine in the Levant. It was one of the first famines, where an estimated death toll was given of 20,000.

Not every famine was caused by drought or environmental conditions.

There were famines in Greece that were caused by war. Farmers were also soldiers. When they were called away for too long, they couldn't harvest their crops, or in a worst-case scenario, they were killed and couldn't bring in the crops.

During the Roman Civil Wars, food was often used as a weapon. Marc Antony, who controlled Egypt, kept grain from Rome to have a strategic advantage over Octavius.

In the year 365, a famine broke out in Rome when the government required people to pay their taxes in grain. It wasn't that there wasn't enough food, it was that food was being diverted to the government.

When the Western Roman Empire fell, there were periodic famines all over Europe which resulted in a large decline in population. It was one of the major reasons why the population of Rome fell 90% over a 400-year period.

In the first millennium, better records were kept, and we see period famines consistently appearing all over. They appeared in Arabia, China, India, Byzantium, Egypt, and North Africa.

These are just the ones we know of. In many cases, the famines are recorded, but not the causes or the scale.

We do know that sometime around the years 800 to 1000, a massive climatic event occurred in Mesoamerica that resulted in a massive famine and the collapse of the Maya Empire. An estimated one million people died.

In 1230, the Kanki famine in Japan was the result of a series of volcanic eruptions. Over a year, about two million people died, which was estimated to be about a third of the population of Japan.

In Europe, famines were occurring about once every few decades. There was a good chance if you lived in Europe, you might have lived through a famine. Most famines resulted in thousands to tens of thousands of deaths.

The 14th century saw some of the greatest famines that the world had ever seen at that point.

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